AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR

USHANT



Date July 27, 1778
Forces British: 30 ships of the line; French: 27 ships of the line
Losses none

Location
Bay of Biscay

The Royal Navy's Western Squadron, commanded by Admiral Augustus Keppel aboard the newly commissioned first-rate *Victory*, met the French Atlantic fleet under the Comte d'Orvilliers about 100 miles (160 km) off Ushant. Keppel attacked against the wind and the two lines cannonaded each other on the same tack. The French began to draw ahead, so d'Orvilliers then wore to pass the British on the opposite tack. The British rear, under Admiral Sir Hugh Palliser, was hard hit by excellent French gunnery and lucky not to be doubled. Keppel wanted to turn to follow the French but Palliser was apparently in no state to perform the maneuver. The inconclusive engagement ended in bitter dispute between Keppel and Palliser, the Royal Navy having failed to fulfil Britain's high expectations.

AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR

FLAMBOROUGH HEAD



Date September 23, 1779
Forces Americans: 5 ships; British: 2 ships
Losses Americans: 1 ship sunk; British: 2 ships captured

Location Off Flamborough Head, Yorkshire

In August 1779 American captain John Paul Jones led a small squadron to raid shipping around the British Isles. Jones was on board the 42-gun converted merchant ship *Bonhomme Richard*, accompanied by the frigates *Alliance* and *Pallas*, both under French captains, and two smaller vessels.

On September 23, Jones surprised a convoy of 50 merchant ships escorted by the 44-gun frigate *Serapis* and a 20-gun escort ship, *Countess of Scarborough*. The first broadside was fired at around 7:00 p.m., with *Serapis* and *Bonhomme Richard* within hailing distance. The British frigate's guns were more effective and it was the nimbler ship. Jones' only chance was to grapple *Serapis*.



French medallion
This commemorative bronze medal depicts the clash between *Serapis* and *Bonhomme Richard* off Flamborough Head.

Carnage ensued, *Bonhomme Richard* scouring *Serapis*'s deck with grapeshot and musket fire while the frigate's guns battered her hull. *Alliance* and *Pallas* forced the *Countess* to strike, but they could find no way to support Jones—when *Alliance* fired at *Serapis*, it caused equal damage to *Bonhomme Richard*. The fight continued by moonlight. *Bonhomme Richard* was on fire and sinking; *Serapis* was also ablaze after a grenade ignited powder below decks. As Jones refused to surrender—apparently saying "I may sink, but I'll be damned if I strike"—*Serapis*'s captain decided to give in and end the slaughter. Jones transferred his crew to the more seaworthy British frigate to return triumphantly to port.



1747–1792

JOHN PAUL JONES

COMMANDED THE AMERICAN CONTINENTAL NAVY AT FLAMBOROUGH

Born in Scotland, John Paul went to sea at the age of 13. Accused of murdering a sailor in Tobago in 1773, he took the name Jones and moved to Virginia. He joined the newly founded Continental Navy in 1775 as a lieutenant and made a reputation as a bold but quarrelsome officer. In 1778, based in France, he demoralized the British by raiding the coast of England and Scotland. After the victory at Flamborough Head his talents were neglected by the United States. He subsequently served in the Russian navy, fighting the Ottomans in the Black Sea as a rear admiral.

AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR

CAPE ST. VINCENT



Date January 16–17, 1780
Forces British: 18 ships of the line, 9 frigates; Spanish: 9 ships of the line, 2 frigates
Losses British: none; Spanish: 1 ship sunk, 6 ships captured

Location Off the Algarve, southern Portugal

Spain's chief war aim in the American Revolutionary War was to regain Gibraltar from Britain. They placed the Rock under siege and naval blockade. In January 1780 British admiral Sir George Rodney was sent to relieve Gibraltar with a strong force of ships of the line and frigates. Commodore Don Juan de Lángara, a strikingly brave and competent Spanish officer, was at sea to the west of Gibraltar, hoping to intercept a merchant convoy bound for the West Indies. A winter storm blew two of his ships of the line off station, leaving him with a weakened squadron of nine ships of the line when he had the misfortune to encounter Rodney's superior British force. As the British bore down upon him, De Lángara had no choice but to run for Cadiz, the nearest safe port.

Rodney ordered a general chase and within two hours, at around 4:00 p.m., the fastest British ships had got among the fleeing Spanish. The 70-gun *Santo Domingo* exploded, killing all on board, but the rest of de Lángara's outclassed ships fought on with notable courage. The battle continued long after night fell. With a strong westerly blowing and a treacherous rocky coast to the lee, there was a serious risk of ships running ashore, but Rodney had no intention of allowing the Spanish to escape and stuck tenaciously to the pursuit. De Lángara's battered flagship *El Felix* was the last of six to be taken, striking its colors in the early hours of the morning. In the aftermath of the battle two of the prizes taken were lost, for in stormy weather off an unfamiliar coast the British could not sail them without using the captured Spanish crews, who eagerly seized back their ships and joined the other escapees in Cadiz.

> "HE NEVER LET SLIP AN OPPORTUNITY TO BRING OPPONENTS TO ACTION, OR BEING HIMSELF IN THE THICKEST OF THE FIGHT"
>
> **ADMIRAL RODNEY,** DESCRIBED BY JOHN KNOX LAUGHTON



The moonlight battle
The *Santo Domingo* explodes during the battle of Cape St. Vincent. The ship to the foreground is the HMS *Sandwich*, flagship of Admiral Rodney.